

MORALIZING; DISPROPORTIONATE REACTIONS; NEEDS

Greetings, my dearest friends. God bless all of you. Blessed is this hour.

Last time, I discussed the importance of becoming aware of your emotions. I spoke about mankind's neglect of emotional development. Tonight I wish to discuss a few important aspects of that which you may expect to find once you allow your emotions to reach surface awareness. These are generally prevalent, and every human being will have all of them in some degree.

After repression is discontinued, you will not only find definite individual negative emotions, such as hostility, resentment, aggressiveness, envy, etc., but in addition to these negative feelings, you will find certain entire conditions prevailing in the psyche. It is important to recognize that these conditions exist, what they mean in terms of reality and maturity, and how they breed the negative emotions about which, consciously or unconsciously, you feel so guilty.

So let me discuss three of such conditions. The first I wish to talk about is a tendency to moralize -- with yourself and therefore also with others. Often such moralizing does not appear outwardly at all. In fact, outwardly the very opposite may be true. But inwardly it exists to some extent with all human beings. We have already discussed this aspect in the past in connection with the idealized self-image, with excessive demands and expectations you have of yourself and therefore of others, with the rigid standards you think you should live up to. But we have not discussed this subject from the point of view of moralizing. For if you expect impossible standards of perfection of yourself, moralizing is a necessary resultant. And I wish to show you how such moralizing stifles the living spirit of the good and the true to which you aspire, how it makes you arrogant and intolerant, how it prohibits the humility of self-acceptance and therefore of liking yourself. Without that, self-respect is impossible.

All this should be found in your emotions. It is one thing to know and understand these theories, but it is altogether different to live and experience these conditions within yourself. Only this work of exploring the depths of your emotions and gaining clarity regarding their significance will make it possible to change these conditions that are so harmful. This aspect of moralizing may exist in many a subtle form, even with those who appear quite rebellious, outwardly, against all moralizing laws and rules.

Many of my friends have naturally encountered this trend in their recent work and in subsequent progress. Regardless of the words used to designate this aspect, the finding of this element definitely shows your progress. Since some of you have come across this aspect, or are about to do so, I shall take up this subject in more detail and show you connections you would not have understood without your progress in this work. This applies also to the other two aspects I shall discuss tonight.

What is the meaning of such moralizing? Offhand, you may say: "What is wrong about it? Are we not taught by all that is good and right, not only in religion, but in all philosophies, the importance of goodness, decency, righteousness? Should we not adhere to these rules? Do we not need them? Without them, we may not be such good people." It is true, as I have so often already stated, that humanity is still far too undeveloped to live without outer laws. When it comes to conduct and actions, such laws serve as protection and are a necessity. But it is altogether different to expect of yourself to be quite free of negative impulses and emotions and to reject yourself because they exist. This nonacceptance of yourself as you still are induces you to hide what you disapprove of; and whenever crisis brings it out, you have a stringent, rigid, moralizing attitude about yourself. It is one thing to know that something is far from perfection. It is another to forbid yourself to feel what you cannot help but feel at this time, and then dislike the whole of yourself -- as is so very, very often the case -- even though you may not be conscious of it.

As long as your "right" conduct is motivated by stringent self-moralizing based on "good or bad," your goodness or righteousness is not genuine. It does not come out of natural insight and inner growth, but arises out of fear, the fear that you harbor about yourself, about your imperfection. Therefore such "goodness" is ineffectual, unconvincing, for yourself as well as for others. It is a compulsion. And you cannot be in reality, for reality cannot be evaluated in terms of either good or bad. When it ceases to apply to very crass issues, the borderlines are subtle, hazy, and no longer capable of being settled by quick judgment in terms of good or bad. The truth can be found only deep within yourself and not from rigid laws and rules you borrow because you are too insecure to delve into your own soul. Instead, you adhere to such ready-made rules, and in the moment when you do so, you moralize.

Any kind of goodness that results out of this condition is always a poor and shallow imitation of the real. Only because you are too insecure to trust yourself, do you think you need rules and regulations to govern you. And since you do so, you cannot lose this insecurity and become rather more and more insecure. This is so because the rules and regulations are mostly so inadequate that you are left with nothing to hold on to. This creates another vicious circle.

In other words, if you do not trust yourself, you have to borrow a rigid structure of morality in order to protect yourself from your untamed instincts. The alternative is not either the living out of these untamed, destructive impulses, or in living according to these rigid outer rules. There really is no alternative at all. The healthy constructive way is through inner growth that must eventually make you come out of destructive impulses. But where this cannot be done as yet because you simply are not that far developed, you need not live them out, but should notice them. You can then see their existence without falling into the error of picturing yourself as all bad, despicable, and black in your own eyes. This exaggeration of your self-evaluation is connected with the second condition we shall discuss in a little while. One imperfection has the power to color your entire emotional experience regarding yourself. This is not an intellectual, conscious judgment, but your emotional reaction to yourself.

Due to this all-black view arising out of only certain negative instincts or feelings, you have an inordinate fear of them. The more you fear these imperfections, the more stringent will be the moralizing structure. The more demanding the standards of perfection are in your idealized self-image, the more rigid will be the superstructure, which is not your real nature. Alienation from

yourself is both the result and the origin of this predicament. Rigidity, fear, insecurity, intolerance -- all these exist in you due to this condition. And this is often projected onto others.

Your idealized self-image is created not only for getting love and approval from others (as you believe it will), but it also serves the purpose of protecting you from yourself.

Wherever there is immaturity and emotional disturbance, there must be found, in one way or another, a superstructure of rigid adherence to rules, which always brings moralizing in its wake. This aspect may often be difficult to detect. It may also exist only in certain isolated areas and manifest in very indirect ways, needing a keen eye for detection. My advice is, do not labor to find this aspect by an artificial and intellectual process, but be aware of the fact that it does exist in you. Expect to find it at some time -- and your work will lead you, sooner or later, to this condition. You will then become fully aware of it and see in what way, concerning what aspects of your inner life, this hold true. Verify how you despise yourself for not living up to perfection, how you do not accept and like yourself because unsuspected negative trends exist in you. Instead of trying to whisk such emotions away, learn to accept yourself in spite of them. Learn to see your real values in spite of the existence of destructive trends. This must be the way. It is the only way. Because you attempt to magic away what still exists in you, it leads to repression and therefore to a false image of yourself. It leads not only to self-deception, but to alienation from your real self in borrowing ready-made rules. This condition produces the moralizing attitude and all the rigidity that is tied up with it.

These rules and regulations in place of your real self may not always be general ones. They vary according to personality, background, early teachings, circumstances, and temperament. General ethics aside, what one person may find wrong and prohibited, another may not.

This structure actually takes the place of the self. Thus you trust in rules rather than in yourself. And this is a very shaky security, for such rules may often be inapplicable to certain reality situations. You may often have to grope and find yourself confronted with a situation of not knowing what the right thing is. However, if you cannot accept yourself as a human being, fallible and often confused, then this unavoidable occurrence has the power to disrupt you completely. You attribute the disruption to the situation itself, but in reality, it stems from your attitude to yourself in connection with the situation. You always want to find the final solution at once. And this urge is dictated by the false belief that you prove yourself unworthy if you admit that you do not know the answer or if you simply have negative, undeveloped reactions. So the first thing to learn on this path now is the ability to accept not only your fallibility, but that you often do not know the answer. If you learn that and at the same time still like yourself, then gradually but surely your emotions will grow up, and your reactions will change, and a healthy trust in yourself, in your natural spontaneous reactions will follow. You will become more lenient with yourself and will no longer need perfection as the only basis for respect.

If it is difficult for you to let go of the superstructure of fixed rules, it is so only because you cannot accept your human fallibility. I purposely refrain now from showing you how the healthy, mature, and flexible person will handle his confusions, his desire to do the right thing. This would only produce a forceful, ungentle inner action on your part, instead of first learning to accept your imperfection without losing faith in the whole you. Once you are a little more advanced in this phase of the path, I will help you with further clues. As of now, more of you feel so unhappy

whenever an issue is befogged, and your known rules and regulations cannot be applied to a situation that bothers you. You first have to discover what bothers you most. This, of itself, is not such an unpleasant situation, but it is only the role that you play in it -- falling short of your ideal of yourself, which requires that you always have perfect reactions and that you instantly know all the answers. When this proves impossible, underneath your bitterness and self-pity, you do not forgive yourself for this imperfection. You moralize with yourself. You find yourself "bad," "wrong," even though you may not allow such opinions into your conscious mind.

This subject needs intensive work. Some of you have begun to discover some aspects of it. With some, it has evolved naturally on their way forward. Some are not quite that far yet, but certain insights will lead to it. So, be watchful for it. Detect the area where in an unforgiving attitude you moralize with yourself for falling short of perfection. Discover where and how you use preconceived and fixed rules to guide you, rather than your own inner conviction arrived at through thorough investigation of the situation and your role in it. Perhaps for some of you, the first steps will be merely to become aware of an inner rigidity and intolerance with self and others. From there, the road leads to further insight in this respect. It cannot be repeated often enough that many a depression and despair is based on expectations from yourself which are impossible to attain.

The second condition I should like to discuss is the matter of your disproportionate reactions, your exaggerations. Again, some of this has been discussed in the past. I mentioned, for instance, how you often overdramatize yourself. But in the way we discussed it previously, it applied more to crass outer manifestations of this aspect, particularly demonstrated by certain personality structures. But this aspect also exists with those who are outwardly very undramatizing about themselves. In other words, it may not show. Yet, on some level of emotional reaction, it always exists. When you proceed and learn to allow your emotions to come to surface awareness and then determine their meaning and significance, you will not only find negative feelings you had been unaware of, not only this moralizing attitude, but you will also discover how you experience certain happenings, your reactions, and the reactions of others as quite disproportionate to their reality value. Again, some of you have already discovered, as a result of work done, that such exaggerated emotional reactions exist. You have begun to sense, at least to some degree and in isolated instances, how overly strong certain reactions are, relative to reality. This applies not only to negative but also to positive or favorable incidents.

This is again based on the childish view of the world as either all good and happy or completely bad and unhappy. You have not yet realized to what degree this attitude still exists in all of you, even those of you who have made some discoveries along these lines. This either/or attitude is the basis for emotional disturbance, immaturity, and ill health as such, but particularly it makes for the moralizing attitude as well as for the disproportionate emotional reactions. (Note that consciously and outwardly this need not be apparent.)

For instance, a little compliment, in itself unimportant, can save the day for you. A passing approval may make all the difference about your mood. By the same token, any little criticism or disapproval may completely spoil your mood. It may plunge you into depression and ill humor. The former disproportionately raises your self-confidence; the latter lowers it. There are many other examples, but you will have to discover these reactions in yourself as you go along, learning to take your emotional reactions out of hiding. In either case, you rise and fall by one single aspect -- whether true or false -- as to how another person thinks or feels about you. In the former case,

emotionally, you feel yourself as being wonderful, good, perfect, lovable, faultless. In the latter case, a little criticism makes you feel as no good at all, at least in the eyes of the other person. This is so hard to detect because intellectually you know so well it is all nonsense, that whenever such reactions do appear, you stifle full evaluation of them. You ascribe your strong reactions to other factors that are not half as responsible, or you simply ignore that which made you react that way. You quickly repress and displace the true origin of your feelings and so move away from reality. You no longer see yourself in relation to the world around you in the light of truth.

The connection between disproportionate emotional reactions and self-moralizing is quite evident. Both are based on an either/or attitude as well as on your own stringent standards for and demands of yourself -- your nonacceptance of your being merely human. Thus approval and compliments makes it appear that you are living up to your expectations of yourself. In that moment, the world is good and right and beautiful. In such childish either/or attitudes, this is it, this is final, until your next disillusionment. And since the world is good and beautiful, you can be what you think you should be. On the other hand, disapproval, criticism, or failure is also final. Now the world is all black and bad. You are unable and are prevented from living up to what you think you should be. The one fault distorts your whole vision, and you are now all bad, hopeless, and, consequently crushed. Thus you are incapable of taking criticism in a constructive way. Yes, you may make the outer gestures and appear to do so, but your inner reactions belie the appearance.

It is often being said that one sign of maturity is the ability to take criticism and frustration in a relaxed, constructive way. I have often mentioned this in the past. The mature person is able to do so because he is in reality. He does not expect the impossible of himself and therefore accepts himself as a decent and likeable human being without being perfect. Therefore he knows that criticism does not make him all bad and all wrong.

The work on this path now calls for awareness of what you really feel, letting out your emotions and true reactions. Without it, you cannot ever find these aspects that prohibit your true growth. It demands of you that you do away with the outer mask of appearance and that you muster the courage of admitting and owning up to such childish reactions. The stronger you hold on to perfectionistic ideals of yourself, the less willing you are to give them up, the more will you resist displaying your emotions where it would be constructive to do so.

Again the procedure is simply to let these emotions come out without trying to change them -- you cannot do so. Simply recognize their existence in you. While you do so, learn to accept yourself with them. This will do more for genuine self-respect than all the forceful, ungentle strivings for a perfection that is simply not attainable through growth. By the mere act of repeatedly observing your childish reactions, the strength of these reactions will lessen. You will become capable of observing such emotions without self-contempt and therefore without repression and without self-moralizing. The nagging, mostly utterly unconscious, suspicion that you are incapable of being what you believe you really should be will subside because you begin to accept yourself. Needless to say, this suspicion is well-founded, only you do not accept the impossibility. You still battle against it. As this suspicion and your anger about yourself subside, you automatically build on real, safe ground, on that which is feasible. Therefore self-confidence will grow proportionately to your acceptance of yourself. You will base your often unconscious opinion about yourself on what is realizable, possible, and feasible. Thus you are secure. While in the old way, you based your

self-respect and self-like on standards that are unrealizable, impossible, and unfeasible. Thus you are insecure. You can be secure only if the expectation is in accord with that which is feasible.

In other words, when criticism comes your way, or frustration of your will due to your own or other people's failings, you can take it in a relaxed way. You know that by this one aspect your whole being is not at stake, that it is actually but one aspect of yourself or of your life. You will then come to trust in yourself and trust that you are capable of taking it in a flexible way, and you are able to learn from such experience. Thus it will not crush you, but it will give you new insight and understanding about self and others. Hence, you will not fear criticism or frustration or failure like the plague, against which you have to guard yourself constantly and set up all your defenses. These defenses are destructive in themselves, as you well know. Without these defenses, your soul will be open and relaxed, always providing you with a perception and inner experience of reality. With such a foundation established, real secure self-confidence and self-respect, not its counterfeit, is the inevitable outcome. Rigid perfectionistic standards result in prohibition of making mistakes, receiving criticism, experiencing failure. All that points to your fallibility, which you do not want to accept. Something in you, deep down, knows perfectly well that you are not perfect, and that therefore you are bound to make occasional mistakes, to receive criticisms, and that you are frustrated from getting what you wish. If you deny this inner knowledge, you deny the truth and try to base your life on false strongholds. If you accept it, you not only accept truth, but you base your life on that which can give you real security. By the proper reaction to your own humanness with all its failings, you build on a rock. By denying it, you build on sand. On these alternatives, the question of security and self-confidence is based.

Observation of these emotional reactions means observing your immaturity. Only by being capable of doing so will maturity grow in proportion. And now we come to a third condition you will find in your observation of your emotions. And that is the subject of needs. This, too, has been discussed in the past to some degree. But with evidence of progress in reaching deeper levels of self-understanding, I can give you a little more material on this subject and show a few more links between these various aspects that, in the past, could only be discussed as unconnected trends, while the inner knowledge was still lacking.

First, let us briefly recapitulate and understand what constitutes a need. A need can be something actual and real, and it can be something quite imaginary and unreal. Let me give you an example of a real need in the physical realm. If you have not eaten for a while, you definitely do need food. If you do not get it, you cannot survive. So this is a real need. By the same token, you can have an unreal need for food. If your body has received all the food value it needs to remain healthy, but if a craving for something not essential persists, then you have an unreal need. Although this unreal need manifests on the physical level, it comes from emotional and/or spiritual disturbance or mismanagements.

On the emotional level, real and unreal needs also exist. The same holds true for the spiritual realm of the human personality. If a real need is neglected due to inner disorganization and mismanagement of the entire human personality, an unreal need will appear somewhere. Unreal needs always have the form of compulsiveness and craving. Mismanagement in that respect will make the person helpless and dependent upon others to have his needs fulfilled.

The difference between children and adults is that a child is actually dependent on all its needs. It is incapable of itself supplying its needs. The truly mature person can do so. With a mature person, if an emotional need is unfulfilled, it need not necessarily mean that this need is unreal. It may well be a real need. But something in him must have made it impossible for him to obtain fulfillment of this need. Everyone is endowed with the capacities he requires in order to fulfill all his needs on all levels. If the personality does not function in a healthy way, some of these capacities will be paralyzed or put into wrong channels.

Since a predominant underdevelopment of man's emotional nature exists, it is logical that there is a predominance of emotional unfulfillment. But such emotional underdevelopment may also result in manifestation on other levels so that physical or spiritual needs may also originate from emotional disturbances. Due to neglect in obtaining one's real needs, illusory or imaginary needs appear. These should be regarded as symptoms of a real unfulfilled need.

Offhand, you may say that an inordinate need for approval is in itself unreal. This need not be so. To a certain degree, every human being needs occasional approval, let us say, in the form of encouragement. If an inordinate and therefore unreal need for approval exists, it is often because the person has unwittingly forfeited his real need for approval, encouragement, success. But instead of resenting the world for not supplying him with it, the growing person will try to discover how and in what way, by what erroneous conclusions and patterns, he himself has shortchanged himself out of what he legitimately needs.

The first step, as always, must be to become aware of your needs. Your path, bringing out the emotions at this point, will help you to become aware of that. After you do so, after you concisely feel the emptiness of an unfulfilled need and can pinpoint it, you can then set out to understand why you denied yourself what you truly need. You have to reconcile yourself to the fact that awareness of your needs, real and unreal, will not immediately fulfill them. You will first have to learn to live with the frustration of an unfulfilled need. You will see that it is possible, and that you can still be quite happy and still have self-respect. This is the ability to take frustration with the mature attitude that nonfulfillment is not an abyss. Only with this attitude can you then find the reasons why and how you caused this unfulfillment. This is a slow way. If you approach it with the perhaps unpronounced attitude that immediate change must occur in your life, you will make it impossible to find what you need to know about yourself.

As you proceed in this direction, you will become aware of the needs as such. Then you will learn to distinguish between real and unreal needs by discovering that real needs can be borne, while false needs have an excessive and compulsive force. You often repress them because they are so strong that, being denied, they make you feel like death.

Now let us find the link between the two aspects previously discussed and unfulfilled needs. For one, you can surely see that all three conditions have the common denominator of the childish either/or attitude. It is impossible to withstand frustration -- an unfulfilled need -- if one regards it as a permanent state, if it is felt that nothing ever good and favorable can be experienced. The child feels, concerning any momentary situation, that "This is it, forever." And your childish emotions, contrary to your mind, still feel that way. You exaggerate the importance. You are permeated with that momentary lack, and you know of nothing else, emotionally. For another, an unfulfillment points to your imperfection, to your vulnerability as a human being. The standards of your

perfectionism do not allow this to happen, or even its acknowledgment. The more you are engulfed in this emotional deviation, the more do you repress your real needs, the awareness of your unfulfillment, and the constructive search derived out of it. Therefore the unfulfillment increases, regenerates itself, and becomes more stringent.

Let us take the following example. To the extent that you are incapable of giving mature love and affection, so will you need to receive love and affection. Or if your need for approval is inordinately strong, it is so in proportion to your disapproval of yourself. And why you disapprove of yourself, we went into when discussing the subject of stringent standards you think you should live up to, and because you cannot do so, you take to moralizing with yourself.

It is of great importance that you become aware of your needs. You cannot do so through intellectual processing. You can only do so if you allow yourself to feel. As you learn to do so, you will be amazed to discover what needs you have. You will then evaluate what in you caused this unfulfillment. The more you gain real understanding and insight about it, the less stringent the unreal needs become, and the more you become capable of having your real needs fulfilled. Needless to say, this lessens your dependency on others. And to that degree, your self-confidence increases.

You find trust in your own strength and resourcefulness in the handling of your difficulties. But all of this necessitates, as a basis, your acceptance of yourself as you are. It is self-evident that in thus entering a benign circle, negative emotions such as self-pity, helplessness, hostility, guilt, resentment, etc., are bound to decrease, until they finally disappear.

These three aspects, my friends, remain to be found and experienced through your feelings. You should experience the depth and width and far reaching significance of these emotions. Then and then only will you enter into a benign circle, after having broken a vicious one.

QUESTION: In connection with moralizing, what would you call righteousness?

ANSWER: It depends in what connection this word is used. It is a matter of interpretation. This word is often used, for instance, in Scripture as doing and being good, as doing the right thing. But in more recent times, this word has taken on a different meaning with many people. When they use it, they think of self-righteousness, of the very moralizing character I have discussed. In fact, it certainly comes from the fact that righteousness is indeed often self-righteousness due to the wrong attitude we considered in detail tonight. It is just a different way of saying that a false goodness, a forceful, ungentle one produces a moralizing that many people rebel against. Genuine goodness coming out of real growth will never have this effect on others.

QUESTION: What about the people who don't go according to morality, but let their emotions guide their lives without recognizing the ethical laws?

ANSWER: I must say that I expected this question. In the first place, let us distinguish between morality and moralizing. These are not the same. In the second place, I never proposed that people should live out in action and conduct what their destructive impulses dictate. It is one thing to be heedlessly and ruthlessly destructive, and another to want to be a saint, to request of you to be a superhuman being, and to not accept your undeveloped side. Accepting does not mean

approving of it or living it out. Accepting merely means that you know these negative aspects still exist in you without anger that you are not above it and without disliking yourself for it as a whole. And this self-contempt, as a whole and not just knowing about certain negative sides in you, is connected with expecting too much, and therefore moralizing.

I might add here that the very people who fling morality into the face of the world -- perhaps because they cannot distinguish between true morality and self-righteous moralizing -- are often most strongly afflicted with a sense of guilt. It may not show. They may displace their guilt feelings by even stronger acts of immorality. It would lead us too far astray now to go into this question in detail. Perhaps at this point, the question can best be summed up by saying your still existing, actual immorality which you are unwilling to face makes you moralize with self and others.

It is very difficult for you to judge what another person's state of mind and emotion is in this respect. You cannot look into it. But the more developed your intuition and your sense of perceiving is, as a result of freeing yourself of your obstructions, the more will you sense it. But this cannot come by judging out of knowledge because you can never have sufficient information about these things. You feel a certain ease and lack of anxiety about wrongdoings of self or others.

As you develop this aspect in yourself, you will perceive intuitively about others where they stand. You will finally come to the point where real morality is alive and flexible in you, and you will then dispense with the practice of false, rigid moralizing. Whoever thought my discussion contained the message of doing away with moral codes has not as yet understood the meaning. But in health and maturity, these existing codes become your own. By following them blindly and self-deceivingly, you take the spirit out of them and make them into something lifeless and untrue. Do you follow what I mean?

QUESTION: No, I don't. It seems to me that you used in your lecture, before the question came in, the word "moralizing." Now, you used morality. It also seems to be that what you termed "moralizing" now, had a different flavor from what you previously called "moralizing" or self-righteousness, and so on. I do not see or understand where the link comes in in what you said now in answer to the question. How can I know when something is right or wrong if I do not compare it with something, like for instance, the Sermon on the Mount or the golden rule? Is that too rigid a rule?

ANSWER: In the first place, I distinguished, in answer to the question, between living morality and lifeless moralizing. Moreover, I explicitly stated that all truth of that which is good and right, brought to mankind by the great ones in history, remains true. Whether or not it is genuinely so or falsely so, depends on man's inner state of being, of his emotions and mind. The mere fact that a person lives according to these great truths neither indicates false moralizing nor true morality based on inner growth, which is based on the real self. The underlying motivations and emotional forces at work indicate that. In many sayings of Jesus, as well as in words of other great teachers, you will find indications and words in support of tonight's lecture. They used their own terminology, fitting their time, but the basic meaning remains the same.

A great part of your question is already answered by the foregoing, and when you study it quietly, you will see it. I do not want to be too repetitious now. Let me only repeat this, the more you need existing rules, the more is it a sign that you do not trust yourself -- because all the truth

ever proclaimed and outwardly taught, lives in you. If you do not dare to go deeply enough into your real being, you will never come to that part of you where you discover it for yourself and thus make it a living reality. You will be dependent on the observation of outer rules. No matter how true and beautiful they are in themselves, they will not be alive and true in you. In man's insecurity, in the fear and denial of that which he still is, he borrows that which was once alive and could again be alive for him. He needs but the courage to become himself, to let go of the rigid structure of that which could and should be alive in him. Do you follow what I mean?

QUESTION: Yes, I do, and then I don't. For instance, if I steal apples, how can I know that I steal if I have no way of comparing this act with another act of not stealing?

ANSWER: My dear child, if you would never in your life have heard that stealing is wrong, you would still know, as the adult person you are, that you take something that belongs to another, and you would know that this is unfair to the other person. Even a human being who is not on a path of self-development and growth would know it if he goes into himself and questions himself on his actions and how they affect others. This taking account of oneself in relationship to others is bound to bring the knowledge of what is right and wrong. This is exactly what I am trying to say -- awareness and taking account, thinking further about cause and effect, will always yield that which is right and true.

QUESTION: But about moralizing, you said that everything is a rigidity.

ANSWER: There is a deep misunderstanding here. You now seem to believe that I implied every moral act is moralizing and rigid. All I invited you to do is to find where these aspects exist in you. You now believe that you should abstain from right actions. This is not so. What you should do, however, is to find where there exists in you superhuman expectations, standards you cannot really live up to in your emotional being, and your nonacceptance of yourself as a whole because of your disapproval of these trends as such. This is the moralizing. Moreover, such moralizing seldom applies to crass issues, but applies only to the subtleties of human interrelationships, where matters cannot be evaluated in terms of good or bad. Moralizing also manifests when, emotionally at least, everything is experienced in such terms of either good or bad, right or wrong.

The fact that you disapprove of asocial or immoral instincts you still harbor induces you to deny their existence in yourself. And this denial leads to moralizing. Your confusion exists in that you feel that awareness of them should mean living them out. Moralizing also exists because you think that disapproval of them need not mean disapproval of yourself as a whole. Now you may certainly be unaware that you do this, yet it is true with every one of you. Your stringent need to be free of any imperfection, of any immoral instinct makes you hide their existence. You feel, "I should not have this," and whenever it trickles into your consciousness, you do not forgive yourself. You hate and punish yourself. All this may be unconscious to a considerable degree, but that does not mean it is not so. You should find this very condition, and this does not mean letting go of all the moral standards you have lived by. Eventually, you will live according to these moral standards out of new motivations, desires, and reasons. And this will have an entirely different effect upon you and on others. It will make for a different climate, so to speak.

Your approach to this subject brought the entire question into a different area, into the area of doing. I was not discussing action. When it comes to feelings, your own emotional attitude to

yourself, the prerequisite of inner truth and therefore of real self-respect can only be based on truth. Now the truth is that you are not as perfect yet as you want to be. If you cannot accept yourself as you are in spite of the instincts you disapprove of, you cannot grow out of them. That is the very nature of the last lecture. I might sum up the inner process in the following way: "If I have destructive instincts, I am horrible and cannot like nor respect myself. Since this is too painful to bear, I must look away from their existence, and hoping that by looking away, they become untrue." Do you now understand a little better?

QUESTION: Yes, I do. But I still don't see where moralizing comes in.

ANSWER: When one judges a whole for only a part, then moralizing occurs. When the whole becomes "black" due to partly "black" trends, or "white" for that matter, then moralizing occurs. When issues are experienced in terms of good or bad, moralizing occurs. There is so much leeway, so much else that has nothing to do with either black or white.

Save your other questions for next time. I have given you much material lately. If out of this material you have sufficient questions for discussion, and you so wish, I shall gladly put in a question-and-answer session next time.

Be blessed, each one of you, in body, soul, and spirit. May the renewed strength you receive, mainly due to your efforts, enable you to know, accept, and like yourself. Be in peace. Be in God!

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